

ones to get the benefits. But be careful about opening and closing too many credit cards because it can give the appearance of unreliability and lower your credit score.

I didn't know anything about credit cards, but some people make it their livelihood to know *everything* about credit cards. One of them is Brian Kelly, known to the Internet as The Points Guy, who runs a website teaching people how to use credit cards to their advantage.

When I interviewed The Points Guy for this book, his first bit of advice was to check your credit score. (His was too low when he began his journey with credit cards, and he had to work hard to bring it up.) It's possible not to have a credit score at all, but chances are you do have one—and it may even predate you! If your parents ever added you as an additional cardholder on their account, for example, you inherited their credit history, which, if it is good, can help you get a credit card. (Yet another point of disparity between those with wealth history or financially savvy parents and those without. This shit starts before you're even born!)

So where and how do you check your credit score?

You are legally allowed to get your credit score once a year for free without your request having an impact on your score. Your score is affected if you have too many “hard inquiries” like those from lenders or collection agencies because they show unreliability, but your score is not affected by “soft inquiries” like those from the three credit bureaus: Equifax, TransUnion, and Experian. (My credit score is a solid 727, by the way, which is the only bit of money information I LOVE telling people. *Time* magazine said in April 2017 that the average credit score for someone in their late 20s, like me, was 652.)



Having a good credit score can be tough. An addict I know checked his credit score for the first time after finally getting sober and found he was screwed. Repairing it required him to get on the phone with multiple financial institutions and government agencies and write many pleading letters. There are credit repair bureaus you can hire to do this, but they might be a waste of money